1. Summary of the evidence

Several experiments have examined whether quitting or reducing social media use improves positive affect, with mixed results. Some report improvements (Allcott et al., 2020; Faulhaber et al., 2023), while others find little change (Przybylski et al., 2021; Vanman et al., 2018), and one reports lower positive affect during the abstinence period (Wadsley & Ihssen, 2023). Across the 19 comparisons in the Appendix , 15 showed no clear effect, three reported improvements, and one found a decline. The findings also suggest that complete abstinence is no more consistently beneficial than limiting daily use. Similarly, a meta-analysis of complete social media abstinence found an average effect on positive affect close to zero, with the confidence interval indicating no more than a small effect in either direction (Lemahieu et al., 2025). However, most interventions lasted about a week and involved university students in Western countries who were recruited and paid to abstain. These limitations make it difficult to determine whether the findings generalise to heavier users, other age groups, or people who choose to take a break from social media on their own.

2. Comparison with the meta-analysis

The appendix, which includes my extraction, shows the direction of findings for individual studies, but the meta-analysis quantifies the overall effect and its precision. Lemahieu et al. (2025) found a negligible, non-significant pooled effect on positive affect (Hedges' $g = 0.03$, 95% CI: −0.11 to 0.16; $p = 0.69$), with substantial between-study heterogeneity (I^2 = 60.7%). This suggests that, overall, complete abstinence from social media did not reliably improve positive affect, although individual study findings varied.

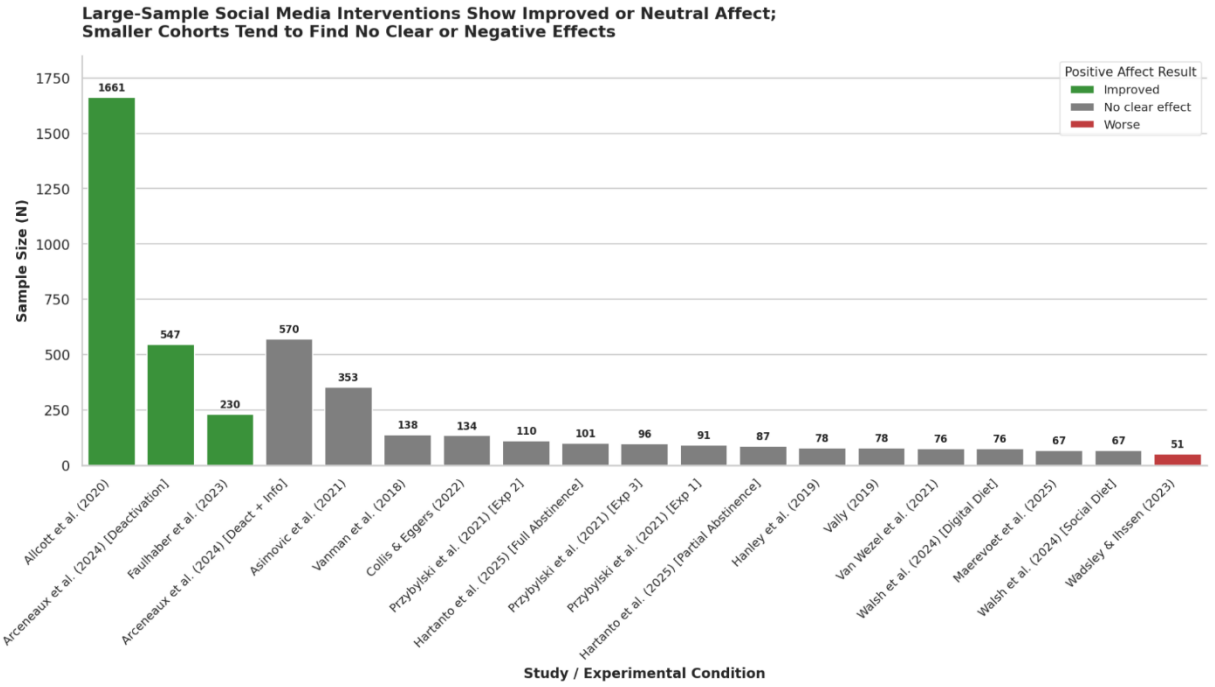
3. Use of AI

I used Gemini Notebook to extract all the information from the table that produced the Appendix and also to create **Figure 1** below.

4. Figure

Below is a bar chart developed from the extracted content in the Appendix.

Figure 1



5. Appendix: Extraction table

Study	Design	Sample description	Intervention	Positive affect result
Allcott et al. (2020)	RCT	1,661; adult Facebook users (≥15 min/day), US	Quit; Facebook; 28	Improved
Arceneaux et al. (2024), Deactivation only group	RCT	547; adult Facebook users and registered voters, France	Quit; Facebook; 28	Improved
Arceneaux et al. (2024), Deactivation + information group	RCT	570; adult Facebook users and registered voters, France	Quit (plus digital literacy/civility messages); Facebook; 28	No clear effect
Asimovic et al. (2021)	RCT	353; Facebook users, Bosnia and Herzegovina	Quit; Facebook; 7	No clear effect
Collis & Eggers (2022)	RCT	134; university students, Europe	Limit; Facebook, Instagram, Snapchat (max 10 min/day combined); 75	No clear effect

Faulhaber et al. (2023)	RCT	230; undergraduate students, US	Limit; multiplatform social media (self-monitored, 30 min/day); 14	Improved
Hanley et al. (2019)	RCT	78; Android smartphone users (aged 18–48), Australia/international	Quit; Facebook and Instagram; 7	No clear effect
Hartanto et al. (2025), Full abstinence group	RCT	101; university students (using social media ≥2 hr/day), Singapore	Quit; Facebook, Twitter, Snapchat, Instagram, Reddit, Tumblr; 7	No clear effect
Hartanto et al. (2025), Partial abstinence group	RCT	87; university students (using social media ≥2 hr/day), Singapore	Limit; Facebook, Twitter, Snapchat, Instagram, Reddit, Tumblr (10 min/app/day); 7	No clear effect
Maerevoet et al. (2025)	RCT	67; bachelor and master students, Belgium	Limit; all social media apps (max 30 min/day); 14	No clear effect
Przybylski et al. (2021), Experiment 1	Within-person	91; young adults, UK	Quit; social media platforms; 1	No clear effect
Przybylski et al. (2021), Experiment 2	Within-person	110; young adults, US	Quit; social media platforms; 1	No clear effect
Przybylski et al. (2021), Experiment 3	Within-person	96; young adults, Hong Kong	Quit; social media platforms; 1	No clear effect
Vally (2019)	RCT	78; university students, UAE	Quit; social media (deleting apps); 7	No clear effect
Vanman et al. (2018)	RCT	138; active Facebook users, Australia	Quit; Facebook; 5	No clear effect
Van Wezel et al. (2021)	RCT	76; university students, Netherlands	Limit; Facebook, Instagram, Snapchat, YouTube (50% screen time reduction target); 7	No clear effect
Wadsley & Ihssen (2023)	Within-person	51; university students (moderate/heavy SNS users), UK	Quit; social networking sites; 6	Worse
Walsh et al. (2024), Digital Diet group	RCT	76; Gen Z university students, US	Limit; smartphone digital media (non-necessary apps); 8	No clear effect
Walsh et al. (2024), Social Diet group	RCT	67; Gen Z university students, US	Limit; social media (Facebook, Instagram, Twitter, Snapchat); 8	No clear effect